Environmental Innovation and Societal Transitions 45 (2022) 72–82

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Environmental Innovation and Societal Transitions

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/eist

Elucidating the capabilities of international mechanisms to foster procedural just system change – The case of the 2021 UN Food System Summit

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Sustainability transition
Food systems transition
Just transition
Food Systems Summit
Participatory justice
Food justice

ABSTRACT

The high ambition of the UN Food Systems Summit (FSS) 2021 was to create system change towards sustainable food systems in a participatory and just way. The new holistic perspective of food systems opened a new arena in which narratives competed for attention. This made the FSS an opportunity to develop and discuss alternative transition pathways, brought forward by less powerful voices. However, profound and sustained critique accompanied the Summit and draws a rather dejected picture of its achievements. By analysing how the procedural justice of the FSS is assessed by actor groups proposing different narratives of sustainable food systems, we examine the opportunities and limits of a global governing body like the UN/FAO to foster system change in a procedurally just way.

1. Introduction

There is broad consensus that current food systems are not sustainable. The existing agrifood system has immense negative effects on human and planetary health, which the Lancet Commission Report (Swinburn et al., 2019) summarizes in the triple burden of obesity, malnutrition and climate change. While the world is still not on track to achieve the second goal of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which aims to end hunger by 2030, the COVID-19 pandemic further complicates the ambitions (FAO et al., FAO, 2020). As a global political response to the urgent need of transforming food systems towards sustainability, UN Secretary General António Guterres announced the UN Food Systems Summit (FSS) was convened in 2021. The Summit wanted to "launch bold new actions, solutions and strategies to deliver progress on all 17 [SDGs], each of which relies on healthier, more sustainable and more equitable food systems" (UN FSS, 2021a). The vision the Summit's organizers wanted to spread is described as follows: "The Summit will awaken the world to the fact that we all must work together to transform the way the world produces, consumes and thinks about food." (UN FSS, 2021b). This aspiration, to initiate a process that will finally lead to a global transformation of the currently unsustainable food systems, in terms of the transition theory could be described as the aspiration to create a landscape shift to trigger transformation.

Research on food systems transformation shows that there are different concepts of what makes food systems sustainable. First, the understanding of the sustainability concept is addressed from different points of view regarding problem description of and proposed solutions to unsustainable patterns (Béné et al., 2019). Second, different framings and narratives of food systems are debated,

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eist.2022.09.002
Received 30 November 2021; Received in revised form 22 August 2022; Accepted 11 September 2022
Available online 21 September 2022
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promoting for example a productivist (or extractivist) narrative or emphasizing the regenerative capabilities of food systems that can contribute to both ecological and human wellbeing (Anderson and Rivera-Ferre, 2021; HLPE, 2019). This latter view also stresses distributional issues such as inequality and human rights (Anderson and Rivera-Ferre, 2021: 19). The question of how to address issues such as social justice and human rights in transition processes has gained increasing attention in the broader field of transformation research (Jenkins et al., 2018; Kaljonen et al., 2021).

With regard to food systems transformation, the active inclusion of marginalized groups beyond industrialized agriculture is key. Indigenous peoples for example possess valuable knowledge on sustainable farming practices. Smallholder farmers are responsible for producing around one third of the food worldwide, but at the same time suffer from poor working conditions that do not enable them to earn a decent living (Anderson and Rivera-Ferre, 2021; Lowder et al., 2021). Since research on justice in transition shows that transformative capacities can be increased by paying attention to and taking into account justice issues in the transition process (Moragues-Faus, 2018), taking a closer look at how justice issues were addressed by the 2021 UN FSS seems promising. Thereby, a special focus is set on the concept of procedural justice as an element of food justice.

The FSS presented itself as a "People's Summit" that invited everyone from everywhere around the world to contribute. While this inclusive approach is a novelty in comparison to prior food summits, the FSS as such has also evoked harsh critique. One of the leading voices was the Civil Society and Indigenous Peoples Mechanism (CSM) in the UN Committee on World Food Security (CFS), which represents different civil society groups. The CSM was established in the course of the 2009 CFS reform "to create greater inclusivity and evidence-based decision-making" (Canfield et al., 2021: 4). By means of agenda-setting and negotiating policy recommendations, the CSM is able to contribute to the CFS's work (McKeon, 2015). While the CSM welcomed the idea of the FSS at first, it formulated several points of critique by responding to an open call to the FSS, which was followed by an exchange of letters with the FSS organizers (Canfield et al., 2021). The critique mainly referred to the selection of leaders and participants, the broad multistakeholder approach blurring human rights as normative basis of the Summit, and the role of strong corporate participation causing conflicts of interest. These conflicts are evident in Agnes Kalibata's dual role as Special Envoy of the Summit and leader of the Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa (AGRA), as well as in the strategic partnership agreement between the FSS and the World Economic Forum (McMichael, 2021; Montenegro de Wit et al., 2021). Moreover, the "evasion of existing institutions and frameworks has led the CSM to conclude that the UNFSS is designed to undermine the position of the CFS as the primary seat of global food governance, which the CSM has fought hard to protect" (Canfield et al., 2021: 8). First ex-post evaluations of the Summit's contribution to more just and equitable food systems find that corporate power, although representing a root cause of current inequalities, was not addressed (Clapp et al., 2021; McMichael, 2021). Overall, the Summit's process and its advances in initiating steps towards sustainable food systems are reported to be reticent or even annihilating (Coutinho et al., 2021; Montenegro de Wit and Iles, 2021; van der Ploeg, 2021).

Given the high ambition of the Summit to create system change towards sustainable food systems in a participatory and globally just way, the critique on the outcomes of the FSS creates doubts about the capability of such an instrument to deliver. Hence, the paper investigates the following research question: *How was the procedural justice of the FSS discussed and assessed by actor groups proposing different narratives of sustainable food systems?*

Thereby, we will examine how procedural justice can contribute to the production of food justice and how procedural structures can give more or less weight to alternative transition pathways brought forward by less powerful voices.

The empirical analysis adopts a qualitative case study design drawing on the analysis of official documents, articles and websites as well as expert interviews with representatives from governing bodies and actor groups in the context of the FSS. The article thus contributes to the growing research on just transitions and applies it to food systems from a global political perspective. The case of the FSS offers the chance to investigate discussions and decision-making processes in a multilateral governance context that includes various actor groups such as UN organizations, national governments, producers, consumers, and academia. Therefore, the article creates new insights on how to include issues of justice in the development of transition pathways aiming at sustainable food systems.

The article proceeds as follows: The second section introduces key concepts we use for our analysis, namely just transitions and transition pathways, food justice, and procedural justice. Section 3 presents the methods and data for the empirical analysis. Next, the empirical results from the analysis are presented and discussed (Sections 4 and 5). Finally, the article draws conclusions and identifies areas for further research (Section 6).

2. Theoretical background: just transitions, food justice and procedural justice

According to Glennie and Alkon (2018: 7), the concept of food justice generally "emphasizes how inequalities in the food system are patterned by race, class, and gender". However, in their literature review in the US context, they find a highly diverse, interdisciplinary and growing research field that additionally takes issues such as food access, agroecology, labour, land use, policy, social movements, alternative practices, urban agriculture and youth into account. It therefore becomes apparent that the notion of food justice does not refer to a distinctive set of parameters, but includes aspects from the entire food supply chain.

Studying food systems transition requires an interconnected and systemic research perspective. A food system "gathers all the elements (environment, people, inputs, processes, infrastructures, institutions, etc.) and activities that relate to the production, processing, distribution, preparation and consumption of food, and the outputs of these activities, including socio-economic and environmental outcomes" (HLPE, 2014: 29). It comprises several sub-systems and interacts with other systems, such as health, energy and trade. In addition, food systems refer to different geographical and organizational scales that address different actors and specific challenges. The transformation towards sustainable food systems – "a system that ensures food security and nutrition for all in such a way that the economic, social and environmental bases to generate food security and nutrition of future generations are not compromised" (HLPE, 2014: 31) – therefore relies on systemic change.

The role of social justice is inextricably linked to sustainability transitions. As Köhler et al. (2019: 16) note, issues of equity and justice reflect the "irreducibly normative impact" of transitions. Although transition research acknowledges the fact that social justice could be addressed by structural adaptation and innovative practices (Grin et al., 2010), a common line to explain and tackle these problems is still missing (Köhler et al., 2019; McCauley and Heffron, 2018).

Despite the lack of a uniform research strand on just transitions, the concept of transition pathways (Leach et al., 2012) appears promising to account for questions of social justice in the context of food systems, since transition pathways explicitly address normativity by connecting environmental sustainability to social justice and poverty reduction. Furthermore, this approach enables the inclusion of "dynamics, complexity, uncertainty, differing narratives and the value-based aims of sustainability" (Köhler et al., 2019: 18) that are central for analysing negotiations in the context of the FSS. The FSS represents a multilateral governance forum in which pathways for the transition of food systems are developed by various actors. "Given the huge diversity of food systems across and within countries, and the diversity of the challenges and constraints they face, actors in food systems will need to design adapted and context-specific transition pathways towards SFSs [sustainable food systems, authors' note] (HLPE, 2016, 2017b). These transition pathways may be grounded in very different narratives, leading to different sets of options for how change is realized." (HLPE, 2019: 26). Hence, narratives consisting of a particular problem framing, an elaboration of what follows from these problems and suggestions how to overcome the problem, build the ground for constructing transition pathways.

Anderson and Rivera-Ferre (2021) have identified such narratives, from which transition pathways can be derived, and subdivided them into extractive versus regenerative narratives. This categorization is based on the "innovative approaches towards sustainable food systems" examined by the HLPE (2019: 63). It differentiates between "agroecological and related approaches" and "sustainable intensification and related approaches". According to Anderson and Rivera-Ferre (2021: 18), regenerative narratives refer to food systems that "provide food for human use but also sequester carbon, preserve biodiversity, produce diverse diets to combat malnutrition, and build community well-being by maintaining farming livelihoods and the social reproduction of culture and farming communities, support the dignity and autonomy of the person and allow severing ties of dependence on external inputs and external knowledge". This definition illustrates that the practical concept of "agroecological and related approaches" to sustainable food systems is rooted in such regenerative narratives. The authors name the practical approaches related to agroecology that are rooted in these narratives, for example "organic agriculture, agroforestry and permaculture" (HLPE, 2019: 15). This category of innovative approaches pays special attention to social aspects of food systems by "emphasiz[ing] reducing inputs and fostering diversity alongside social and political transformation focused on improving ecological and human health and addressing issues of equity and governance." (HLPE, 2019: 15).

Proponents of extractive approaches, on the other hand, "view enhancing productivity and food availability as a technological challenge to be solved by applying techniques familiar from other businesses (e.g. utilizing economies of scale, digitalization, breaking down complex tasks into simple repetitive steps)" (Anderson and Rivera-Ferre, 2021: 20). These approaches are rooted in extractive narratives and can be referred to as the currently dominant paradigm of how to achieve food security (HLPE, 2019). The focus of these approaches is less concerned with reducing inputs and social aspects, as they come from "a premise that, to address future challenges, productivity per unit of land needs to increase in a sustainable manner, which is what is meant by sustainable intensification" (HLPE, 2019: 15).

We consider the FSS an arena that comprises several actor groups with different backgrounds and interests who debate such competing narratives regarding sustainable food systems. Against this background, we investigate how procedural structures can hinder or release the lever of dominant narratives. In doing so, we aim to make alternative transition pathways brought forward by less powerful voices visible. To this end, the concept of procedural justice is crucial.

Procedural justice refers to fair decision-making processes which allow different actor groups to participate and contribute their preferences and values (Larcom and van Gevelt, 2017; Schlosberg, 2009; Tomlinson, 2015). Analyses of procedural justice basically ask who is included in such processes and how (Maughan et al., 2020). In this regard, procedural justice is closely connected to the concept of participation in the global arena. As Brem-Wilson (2015) elaborates on the case of the reformed CFS, there is a number of conditions for participation of affected people to be effective. These include being informed about specific modes of communication, the ability to spend money and time on processes and being formally admitted to the discourse. Decisions taken under procedurally just conditions are more likely to be perceived as legitimate by the people affected (Dixon et al., 2016). Procedural justice also has an impact on the decisions taken as well as on the actual benefits for those in need (Horst, 2017; Moragues-Faus, 2017). Although procedural justice is a decisive element for institutional design and of great value in political institutions, it is hardly addressed in policy proposals (Tomlinson, 2015). In a conceptual review of energy justice, Jenkins et al. (2016) identify three mechanisms of inclusion to enhance procedural justice in decision-making processes: local knowledge mobilization, information disclosure and institutional representation. Mobilizing local knowledge implies that "the inclusion of knowledge, discourse and stories in our decisions can make a significant impact on policies" (Jenkins et al., 2016: 178), especially if physical involvement is not possible. Full information disclosure, e.g. by the leadership team of a political decision-making process, facilitate meaningful participation and engagement. Representation in institutions is an indispensable condition for just transitions. Particularly inequalities regarding gender and ethnic minorities in governing bodies have often been reported (Jenkins et al., 2016).

3. Methods and data

To analyse the Summit's potential contribution to a just transition of future food systems, the empirical analysis builds on a qualitative approach using interpretive methods. These include the qualitative analysis of official documents, articles and websites as well as expert interviews conducted with various representatives of actor groups in the context of the FSS, such as FSS governing

bodies, UN organizations, member states, civil society organizations, research institutions, and the private sector. The analysed documents primarily describe and discuss solutions and action areas to achieve sustainable food systems and are publicly accessible via the FSS website. Interestingly, some of the documents map the whole process from first conceptual ideas, e.g. in each of the five Action Tracks, to the consolidated solution clusters presented at the actual Summit in New York. Therefore, the documents provide the opportunity to track the main developments and partly also conflictual aspects. In this regard, the document analysis created a valuable basis of background knowledge for further analysis by means of expert interviews.

Interview data help gaining a deeper perspective in the actual working processes and decision-making mechanisms that are not mentioned in official documents. The expert interviews were conducted online using a semi-structured questionnaire to guarantee comparability. In sum, 20 expert interviews were collected, coded and analysed using MAXQDA. The interviewees are participants of the Summit, representing all five Action Tracks (ATs): two participants from AT 1, one from AT 2, two participants each from AT 3 and AT 4 as well as one participant from AT 5. There is also one participant each from member states in Asia, Africa, Oceania and South America, as well as two from Europe. Furthermore, we interviewed two members of the High Level Panel of Experts on Food Security and Nutrition (HLPE), which is the science-policy interface of the CFS. One representative of civil society organizations as well as one of the Philanthropic Foundations were also interviewed, as well as two members of the Champions Network and one participant of the alternative Summit launched by the CSM. Three of the interviewees are closely connected with the CFS and its related bodies. Some of the interviewees also represent more than just one institutional entity or role within the Summit's process. Furthermore, the more than one-year-long process of the Summit has been attentively followed by the researchers, who have observed the Pre-Summit and the Summit itself, as well as public events such as the UN FSS Science Days, Global Summit Dialogues and Individual Independent Dialogues.

The subsequent analysis of the interviews followed a mix of deductive and explorative approaches. By asking the interviewees for their problem definition regarding currently unsustainable food systems as well as the proposed solutions they bring forward at the Summit and by analysing their sustainability and system understanding, it was possible to identify whether they related more to regenerative or more to extractive narratives and their associated practical approaches to sustainable food systems. This deductive part of the analysis refers to criteria derived from the narratives' systematization by Anderson and Rivera-Ferre (2021) and the HLPE (2019). Attention was paid, for example, to whether the interviewees' definition of the problem referred primarily to insufficient food production worldwide, and whether they preferred sustainable intensification measures and, in particular, technical solutions as proposed solutions, as tends to be the case within extractive narratives. This perspective is often described as less transformative (HLPE, 2019), as it is based on a less systemic view of food systems that largely ignores social aspects, for example. In contrast, other problem definitions of unsustainability and proposed solutions put forward in the interviews were based on more systemic perspectives that entailed a stronger transformative claim. The solutions proposed within this perspective were more likely to involve social and political aspects and were not limited to incremental and technical proposed solutions. Thus, these arguments could be assigned to the regenerative narratives. Overall, 42 per cent of the interviewees brought together perspectives from both narratives. In these cases, the assignment of their arguments to the respective narrative was based on whether the rationale for that particular argument more closely matched the criteria of the extractive or regenerative narratives. Of the remaining 58 per cent who could clearly be assigned to the two narratives, 66 per cent were associated with regenerative narratives, while 34 per cent used arguments coming from extractive narratives. A further deductive element of the analysis consists of the three mechanisms of procedural justice identified by Jenkins et al. (2016) and described in Section 2. The framework provides a very useful analytical lens with regard to our research question, as it takes participative as well as institutional elements into account. It thus helps us to inquire about the interviewees' perspective on their own ability to contribute to the decisions taken at the FSS as well as for the formal setting that might have supported or hindered participation. The first mechanism, local knowledge mobilization, asks if and to what extent local knowledge is included in the decision-making processes. The second mechanism is information disclosure: Do all the participants of the Summit have full and easy access to all relevant information they need to contribute? Who disseminates the information and how fast and inclusively, e.g. with regard to language, is it distributed? The third mechanism focuses on the institutional representation, especially of marginalized groups, in the structure of the FSS. Can they voice their positions and demands and thus contribute to the working processes in an institutionalized way? However, this part of the analysis was also carried out with a special attention for elements of participatory justice in the context of food justice that were brought up by the interviewees themselves. This was done in order to be able to contribute to two research questions posed by Kaljonen et al. (2021: 480) that are formulated as follows: "How to support the equal participatory capabilities of different groups, especially those who are presently marginalized and vulnerable or suffer from power disparities? […] What kinds of decision-making procedures support the fair consideration and deliberation of conflicting food values and justice claims with respect to transition?"

4. Results

To provide an overview of the most important bodies of the UN FSS process, Fig. 1 shows the structure of the FSS. Much of the substantive work was done in the Action Tracks at the beginning of the process. They had different foci, namely "Ensure access to safe and nutritious food for all" (AT 1), "Shift to sustainable consumption patterns" (AT 2), "Boost nature-positive production" (AT 3), "Advance equitable livelihoods" (AT 4) and "Build resilience to vulnerabilities, shocks and stress" (AT 5). Eventually, the results of the five ATs' work as well as the reports and results of the other bodies were condensed and consolidated within the frame of a complex multi-step process.

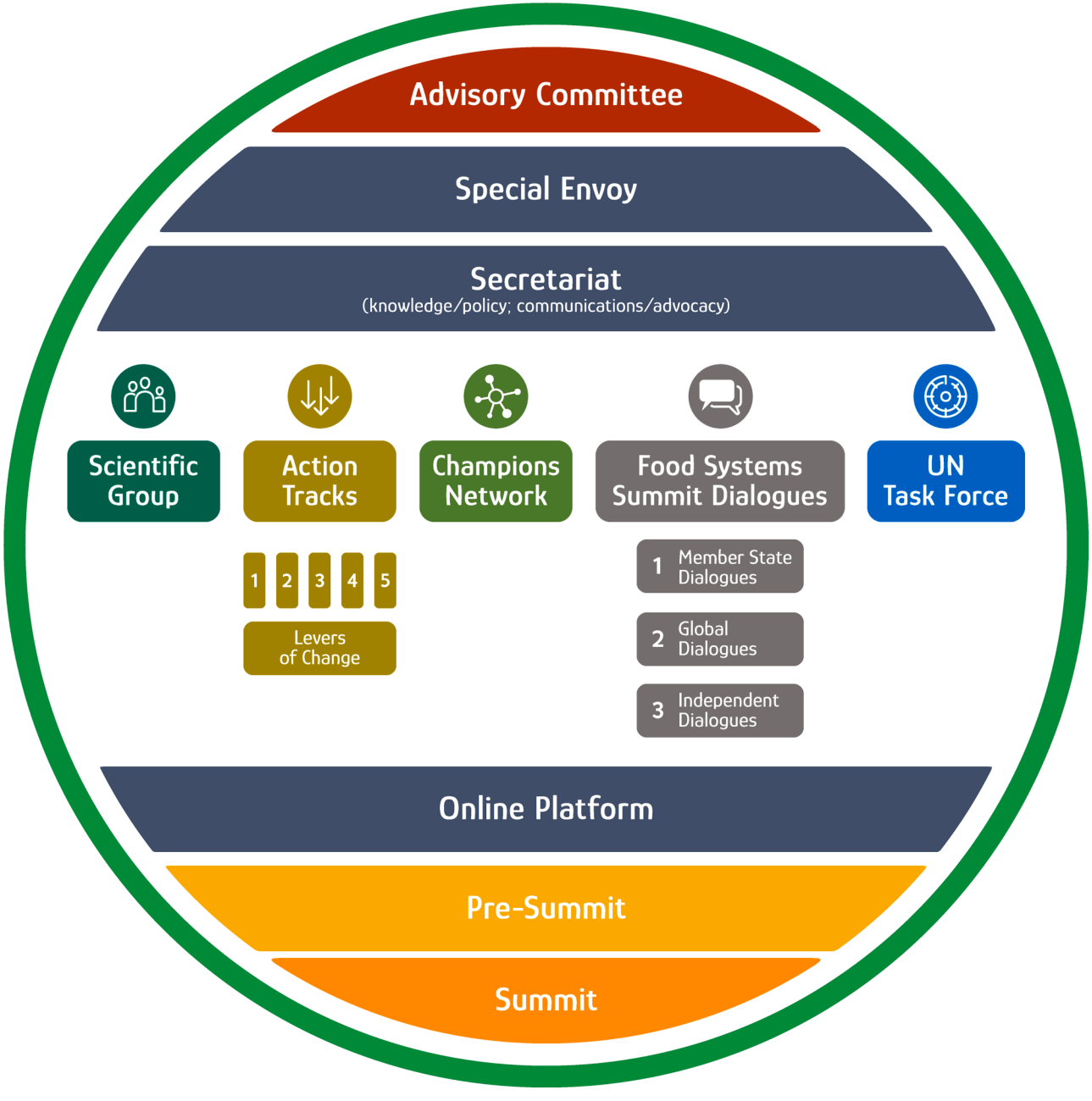

Fig. 1. Structure of the FSS (UN FSS, 2021a).

4.1. Local knowledge mobilization

Jenkins et al. (2016) consider the mobilization of knowledge crucial to create procedurally just processes. In their paper, they refer especially to energy justice and therefore they primarily consider the inclusion of indigenous peoples. In the context of the FSS, however, the mobilization of local knowledge also relates to all other stakeholders of food systems, in particular to those who had difficulty accessing decision-making processes in the past due to power disparities.

In general, the arguments of both narratives have put forward both positive and negative arguments regarding the mobilization of local knowledge in the context of the FSS process. It became clear that those interviewees rather in favour of regenerative narratives were much more dissatisfied with this process, while those rather supporting extractive narratives assessed the mobilization of knowledge in the context of the FSS rather positively. Table 1 gives an overview of the results regarding the first mechanism of procedural justice.

The main positive arguments highlighted were that all people globally were invited to take part in the process, to express their opinions and to be heard. Many people from very different contexts also accepted this invitation, which was also appraised. Namely, representatives of the youth, indigenous peoples, smallholder farmers, and women, as well as private sector and philanthropic foundations were involved. In the interviews that referred more to the extractive narrative, the boycott of the FSS by the CSM was mentioned several times. Interviewees described this as incomprehensible, since the CSM members were invited to express their position within the FSS process.

> *"There are some civil society groups who are challenging the Food Systems Summit because they do not view it as participatory enough, which is fair enough. But I think this is a different kind of summit. Do not look at what we say in words and criticize that for not saying it the way you want us to say, join us and change it. […] We have a door open to anybody who wants to join and shape the thing going forward […]. The Summit will come up with words. Words are not important. Action is what is important. And so that to me is an innovation, an institutional innovation in and of itself" (I7).*

On the other hand, the interviewees who viewed the mobilization of local knowledge in the FSS process critically painted a somewhat more complex picture. They confirmed the impression that anyone who wanted could participate in the FSS process. However, it was also often reported that the views and positions brought in by some participants were without further notice left behind in the course of the Summit process.

> *"Some words are included here and there about the recognition of [local knowledge]. There was a paper commissioned, for example, on indigenous people and their role and their knowledge systems. But what will be the impact of having that? I am not sure it will make any difference. We can say yes, we ticked the box. […] But all the recommendations, if they still go in the direction of what business wants, then we are in trouble. So I do not want to be too pessimistic, but it will need a lot of adjustments between now and [the Summit in, authors' note] September if we want to have a better representation of all the interests. And I think that certainly the majority of the people that are affected by the food systems in the worst way have been very poorly represented in the system so far" (I1).*

The fact that the existing structures for the participation of the civil population at UN level, the CSM, were not included at the beginning of the process has been subject of the extensive criticism from the start. The Champions Network was created as a space for

Table 1
Assessment of local knowledge mobilization by representatives of the two narratives.

Extractive narratives	
Positive assessment	• Many people participated • People from diverse backgrounds participated (from all parts of civil society) • Awareness for the need to transform food systems has been successfully raised • There is no need to criticize the Summit from outside, since everyone could join • Everyone who wanted could join, bring their perspectives in, and was listened to • Organizers of the Summit's bodies were advised to listen to everyone • Especially the national dialogues had a huge outreach
Negative assessment	• The Summit was inclusive (many people participated), but not just (no mechanisms to balance power)
Regenerative narratives	
Positive assessment	• Many people participated • People from diverse backgrounds participated (from all parts of civil society) • Awareness for the need to transform food systems has been successfully raised • There is no need to criticize the Summit from outside, since everyone could join • After critique by civil society organizations knowledge mobilization was improved
Negative assessment	• Existing structures (CFS/CSM) were ignored at the beginning, also secretariat did not listen to the conditions for participation they communicated • Many participants had the feeling they could bring in their perspectives and demands, but they were simply not taken up in the further process • If participants in the Champions Network must be approved from top-down, their positions do not necessarily stand for civil society groups

leaders from institutions and networks, as well as representatives of the civil society. However, its composition was viewed rather critically in the interviews, as it was not developed from an autonomous dynamic process like the CSM, but consisted exclusively of members who had to be confirmed by the Special Envoy.

4.2. Information disclosure

Regarding the information disclosure, supporters of both types of narratives agreed that the Summit process had a rather opaque organization. Some mistakes that were made, such as the initial delay in providing documents and reports, were addressed over time. Still, many participants felt disconnected from the decisions that were important to the process moving forward. From the beginning on, it seemed opaque how decisions were made about the governance structure of the Summit. Table 2 summarizes the findings on the second mechanism.

Although the individual bodies, for example the Action Tracks, National Dialogues and the Champions Network, allowed participation in the form of contributing one's own ideas, comments, criticism, and remarks, the stakeholders were not involved in the further processing of these findings, nor were they informed about how exactly these steps looked like. Since there were several steps involved in condensing and further processing ideas, the participants were left with the impression of being far disconnected from the decision-making bodies.

> *"[There is] the process for developing the call for action as a non-negotiated document, but still. How did different things get into there and others were excluded? Did they choose the list of coalitions that were chosen as the top nine at the Pre-Summit? No one knows. And [there are] the coalitions that are getting supported as opposed to those that are not getting supported, even though there is a lot of member countries and others behind them. So there has been a lot of lack of clarity and lack of transparency at times" (I16).*

Furthermore, it was not clear from the outset what the course of the process leading up to the Summit would be. Often, participants contributed without knowing in which way the collected suggestions and information would be further processed. Overall, the Summit process left the impression of opacity and lack of transparency.

4.3. Institutional representation

When Jenkins et al. (2016, 179) emphasize unequal institutional representation, it is especially gender and ethnic minorities' representation they are referring to. This view was taken up by interviewees from both narratives and supplemented by the institutional representation of other marginalized groups, such as indigenous peoples and smallholder farmers. Table 3 presents the findings regarding the third mechanism of procedural justice.

Several interviewees rather supporting regenerative narratives, however, emphasized an important difference in framing the concept of inclusion between the narratives. For them, the term referred primarily to stakeholders who had previously been excluded from decision-making processes and therefore deserved special attention. In contrast, the concept of inclusion was used by the organizers of the Summit and applied equally to all stakeholders, including, for example, multinational corporations which already had enough resources to make their voices heard.

> *"We have been listening to farmers' groups and youth groups and women's groups and business groups and governments. We are talking to governments regularly, and many others. And we have solicited ideas. We call them solutions, game changing solutions, from anybody on our website. And we have received more than 2000 of them" (I7).*

Many interviewees emphasized that existing power structures among Summit participants were not balanced. This had led to actors with more time and financial resources being able to articulate their opinions most loudly, for example because they were present with more participants on the Summit's various platforms and were better able to consolidate their positions with other actors having similar interests. Little attention was paid to this fact, which had given large corporations a major advantage not only over civil society, but even over poorer member states. Thus, different entry conditions and power disparities could not be compensated.

Table 2
Assessment of information disclosure by representatives of the two narratives.

Extractive narratives	
Positive assessment	• There were a lot of opportunities to ask tough questions to the Summit's organizers
Negative assessment	• Several layers of disconnection between the different steps of the process
Regenerative narratives	
Positive assessment	• Websites, reports and documents are all accessible
Negative assessment	• Several layers of disconnection between the different steps of the process • Setting up the governance structure of the Summit and deciding about the themes for the Action Tracks was an opaque process • Process of the Summit (bringing in ideas in Action Tracks, formulating Solution Clusters that evolve into coalitions) was not clear from the beginning

Table 3
Assessment of institutional representation by representatives of the two narratives.

Extractive narratives	
Positive assessment	• Many groups of civil society, young people, women, and indigenous peoples participated • All stakeholders were represented • Advisory committee was well balanced • Even if the CSM, who boycotted the Summit, says that the civil society representatives of the Summit do not speak on behalf of them, they still represent the civil society, since they are part of it • Institutional representation of marginalized groups has been improved throughout the process after criticism
Negative assessment	• *no statements identified*
Regenerative narratives	
Positive assessment	• Many groups of civil society, young people, women, and indigenous peoples participated
Negative assessment	• The CSM has emerged in the international arena as an autonomous space for civil-society, whereas the participation process in the FSS is artificial, since participants in the Champions Network must be approved by the Special Envoy ("astroturfing") • CSM would have participated if they had been given appropriate representation at higher levels • Participants had no saying in how the FSS process should evolve/continue (Centralized decision-making) • The mere opportunity to bring in ideas and critique does not equal representation – it must also have consequences • Power was not balanced (marginalized people and poorer countries have less time, resources, manpower) • If participants in the Champions Network must be approved from top-down, their positions do not necessarily stand for civil society groups

"I think [the FSS] is certainly more inclusive than processes in the past, but I am not quite sure if it is just. For example, those impacted may not have been able to participate in the Summit because of the complexity of the process itself. You would need to have a full time job following the Summit to actually be able to input into it. The sort of intended beneficiaries of the process, say poor farmers or people deprived of health or other issues of justice, do not really have clear means of participating. Therefore, I am not quite sure if it is necessarily inclusive in that sense. The result that we have is that the loudest voices are the best heard, not necessarily the ones that need to be heard from a perspective of justice and inclusion" (I15).

"The FSS is an attempt to address the shortcomings of multilateralism through multi-stakeholderism. Meaning they treat a government like a stakeholder, just like everybody else. It flattens things out. And it privileges those who already have power. […] They say everyone can participate, but the more money and resources you have, the more you can influence the process. That is the architecture" (I18).

Regarding the institutional representation, it was also emphasized that the missing representation of the CSM could not be adequately replaced in the Summit process. The participation of various civil society groups within the Champions Network was described as "astroturfing" by strong supporters of regenerative narratives, alluding to an artificial establishment of an alleged grassroots movement. Interviewees rather supporting regenerative narratives of food systems transformation also criticized the centralized decision-making mechanisms of the Summit's process, which could not be influenced by participants. They again referred to the fact that proposals and ideas that were submitted and also endorsed by many participants were not incorporated into the further documents as the process progressed. This resulted in the impression that the organizers of the Summit were pursuing a "hidden agenda".

5. Discussion

The aim of this paper was to shed light on the arguments put forward by extractive and regenerative narratives in order to assess to what extent the Food Systems Summit 2021 made procedural justice possible. With this we examined how procedural justice can contribute to the production of food justice and how procedural structures can hinder or enable the lever of dominant narratives in order to make visible alternative transition pathways brought forward by less powerful voices.

The interviews reveal clearly that those interviewees rather supporting the dominant extractive narrative assess all three aspects of procedural fairness that Jenkins et al. (2016) rank as important more positively. The two narratives have the greatest similarities in their assessment of the FSS with respect to the aspect of information disclosure. The vast majority of interviewees were rather dissatisfied with the provision of information. Initial problems with the provision of documents or non-existent translations of verbal contributions in meetings were quickly resolved. Nevertheless, participants felt disconnected from decisions about the course of the Summit process and found it unclear why some issues survived the process of condensation and consolidation and others did not.

The local knowledge mobilization for the Summit received the most positive evaluation by the interviewees. Overall, the intention of the FSS to achieve the broadest possible mobilization of local knowledge and thereby to create awareness of the urgency of transforming food systems was met with positive feedback from both narratives. However, the failure to engage existing UN-level civil society participation structures, namely the CSM, at the outset of the Summit process was met with massive and sustained criticism. The impression here is that the initial setting of such a process, which is intended to be just and broadly participatory, is vitally important for the further course of the process and for the societal perception.

The conceptualization of institutional representation by Jenkins et al. (2016), which focuses particularly on gender and ethnic minorities' representation, was extended by the interviewees to all stakeholders of food systems. However, it was noticeable that supporters of regenerative narratives placed a special focus on particularly vulnerable and marginalized groups, while interviewees whose perspective was rather rooted in extractive narratives hardly considered existing power imbalances of the different stakeholders. This latter view, the equal treatment of all stakeholders, regardless of their position in society and food systems, is also discussed as multistakeholderism (Pigman, 2007) and is also heavily criticized with regard to the FSS (Canfield et al., 2021).

The Champions Network was created to provide a space for leaders of institutions and networks and representatives of civil society. However, its composition was criticized because it was not developed from an autonomous dynamic, as the CSM was, but consisted exclusively of members who had to be confirmed by the Special Envoy. In the literature on deliberative democracy, this is negotiated under the concept of authenticity and also associated with social movements and transition initiatives (Felicetti, 2017).

6. Conclusions

The high ambition of the UN FSS 2021 was to create system change towards sustainable food systems in a participatory and globally just way. As Canfield et al., 2021 note, the new perspective on food and nutrition that emphasizes the holistic view of food systems opened a new arena in which narratives competed for attention. The challenging of dominant production-focused narratives could have made alternative, regenerative narratives of sustainable food systems visible. Thereby, the FSS was an opportunity to develop and discuss alternative transition pathways, brought forward by less powerful voices that are based on these alternative narratives. However, the profound and sustained critique that accompanied the Summit and draws a rather dejected picture of its achievements raises doubts about the capabilities of such an instrument to meet the ambition of creating system change towards sustainable food systems in a participatory and globally just way. To investigate this, we have shed light on the arguments put forward by extractive and regenerative narratives in order to assess the extent to which the FSS made procedural justice possible, as well as to elucidate the capabilities of international mechanisms to foster procedurally just system change.

The UN FSS 2021 was able to demonstrate through its extensive mobilization of local knowledge that a broad participation process at the international level is possible and generates positive feedback from participants. It was able to attract many participants from all parts of the world and with different backgrounds and interests, who contributed their views on food systems and sustainability. This process also raised widespread awareness of the need to transform our food systems toward sustainability. Some supporters of regenerative narratives also expressed positive surprise at how prominently they were able to place agroecological approaches, despite seeing power disparities as overwhelming to their detriment.

Research on justice in transition shows that transformative capacities can be increased by paying attention to and taking into account justice issues in the transition process (Moragues-Faus, 2018). In addition, transition literature emphasizes that the questioning and shifting of existing power constellations can create opportunities for transformative change. Consequentially, we conclude that the potential for a setting such as the FSS to support the emergence of new narratives, and thus highlight new transition pathways, is high.

Nevertheless, the other two criteria for achieving procedural justice could not be convincingly met by the FSS. Interviewees, especially those supporting the less dominant regenerative narratives, tended to rate information disclosure and institutional representation quite negatively. This is mainly due to a lack of balancing of power disparities, opacity of the Summit's decision-making processes, and ignoring existing UN-level participation mechanisms at the beginning of the process. Also, the members of the Champions Group were not accepted as representatives of the interests of civil society, since they had to be confirmed by the Special Envoy. Felicetti (2017) discusses this phenomenon as lacking authenticity. Another point that is also taken up in his discussion of deliberative democracy and transition initiatives in the public sphere is the demand of people in participatory processes to see their input really influencing the outcomes of the process. If this is not the case as has been reported with regard to the UN FSS 2021, he refers to it as lacking consequentiality. Our research findings suggest that the retention of power by dominant, extractive narratives in the multistakeholder context of the FSS was successful. Despite the Summit's transformative aspirations, voices prevailed whose narratives were more about business as usual than bringing about real change. Thus, the question arises whether there are fundamental limitations to such a setting that allow procedural justice only within a certain framework and thus have a limited capacity to initiate transformations. However, the ignoring of existing UN-level participation mechanisms, in particular the CSM, at the beginning of the process rather indicates that the FSS was initiated by powerful coalitions supporting the incumbent narratives (Roberts et al., 2018). Similar to what Johnstone and Newell (2018: 72) emphasize for the role of the state in transformations, it can be assumed that the multilateral context and such summits play "multiple and conflicting roles", that still need further examination.

This very recent summit has once more demonstrated that – even if there is some intent by some actors in the multilateral system – the UN and the FAO are hardly able to create system change and need to be transformed themselves in order to do so. Both institutions were created and shaped after the Second World War and focused on challenges of the 20th century with all its merits and shortcomings broadly discussed. However, creating system change and changing persistent power relations to achieve just food systems at a global level is *the* challenges of this very century and obviously overburdens the UN/FAO in its current constitution. This does not come as a surprise consulting the knowledge on transition studies published in this and other journals over the last two decades. Specifically, the UN and the FAO lack the transformative capacity to create system change, which would, among other apsects, require transformative leadership, a shared transformative vision and mechanisms to embed grassroot innovations (e.g. connected to the regenerative practice) into the system (Wolfram 2016; Ehnert et al., 2018, Augenstein et al., 2020). These prerequisites were all hardly seen in the FSS.

To transform the UN/FAO in order to increase their transformative capacity should be considered as one of the main strategic

objectives in the upcoming years. Some see the FSS already as a "jumpstart […] that potentially reconfigures global food governance, bypassing existing intergovernmental institutions with both the mandate and legitimacy to address these issues" (Montenegro de Wit et al., 2021: 153). Others refer to "the reform of the UN Committee on World Food Security triggered by the 2007–2008 food price crisis [that] established a strong precedent for what could be called 'inclusive multilateralism' in which civil society and social movements are full participants, but decision-making is reserved for governments, who hence can be held accountable" (Montenegro de Wit et al., 2021: 154; McKeon, 2021). Both strands outline the difficulties and possible trade-offs that come along with such changes. In any case, to initiate and implement a transformation of the UN/FAO multilateral system by design most likely will take decades, as it is a subject of the multilateral system itself and therefore dependent on its slowness in decision-making. Hence, we conclude that both is needed an increasing pressure on the UN/FAO to transform themselves and an increasing transformative capacity of actors and institutions outside the multilateral system to foster just system change in the food sector.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

Acknowledgments

The paper is based on research co-financed by the Permanent Representation of Switzerland to FAO, IFAD and WFP, Rome, Italy. We thank the staff of the Representation for their extraordinary efforts to establish the contacts to many of our interviewees and for the sharing of their knowledge and experiences to better understand the multilateral governance system of the UN/FAO. We further thank Carla von Pappenheim for her valuable support as a student assistant during all phases of the project, especially regarding the collection and analysis of the empirical data. We thank the editors of this special issue, the participants of the session during the International Sustainability Transitions Conference 2021 and the two unknown reviewers for their critical and very constructive feedback to previous versions of this paper.

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